

Commented [DF1]: moontower, personally I like to add W2026 somewhere too, just to help keep track of the projects, I always get the names mixed up since they change halfway through usually.

Learning Objectives

- Finalize Game Vision and Visual Identity ~~decision~~s with peers while incorporating feedback.
- Document game design requirements.

Commented [DF2]: decisions

Milestone Zero Assignment

Your final Game Studio group project is a vertical slice of a game. Before you can move from the ideation phase into production, you must first finalize your core game vision and visual identity.

In this assignment, you will:

- Refine your game design doc based on feedback, while porting the content to Figma.
- Solidify your game's visual identity and aesthetic to ease the creation of unified assets and environments.

If this milestone is solid, sprint planning can start immediately without debate. If it's vague, you will lose time to rework.

Deliverables

The following 3 Figma-based deliverables are required for milestone zero:

- Answers to Feedback Questions:** Review all the feedback in Appendix A. As a group, discuss the feedback and answer the questions posed. Submit the questions and their answers.
- Game Design Document (GDD):** To ensure your GDD remains a living document, you're going to refine and port seven GDD sections into your project Figma. See Appendix B for details.
- Visual Identity / Style Pillars:** Lock in a clear visual target and style pillars for your game to ensure that every asset, animation, and UI element feels like it belongs to the same world. See appendix C for details.

Accountability: In the Learn Dropbox comment, list which students worked on each of the three deliverables.

Marking Rubric and Late Policy

You will find the full marking rubric in appendix D. Late submissions will result in an immediate 20% penalty deducted from the possible assignment mark, and another 20% for each 24-hour period that the assignment is late.

Appendix A – Game Design Document Feedback and Questions

Feedback to be Discussed as a Group

Game Vision Refinements

Narrative: There should be a short, simple, and clear story to act as a scaffold for gameplay decisions.

Hook / Fantasy: What do players *do* in the game and what makes them *feel* cool while playing.

Elevator Pitch: What you'd say to someone at grad show who asks "What's your game about?". You probably aren't diving too deep into lore. Instead, you're providing a functional description of the gameplay and objectives.

Target Audience: You've currently listed "Memorizing enemy behaviour" and "Experimenting with novel playstyles and combinations", neither fits well with a playthrough from a Grad Show attendee.

Vertical Slice Project Scope

Scope-wise, please respect the project goal of a *vertical slice demo* of a game. The game devs at Motion Twin worked on Dead Cells for four+ years. You have 11 weeks in which you can do amazing things, if you can manage your scope!

Your Game Design Document listed playtimes of 10-15 minutes with runs of 3 procedurally-generated city tiers. This is too large of an experience to build and polish in 11 weeks. Playtesting a 15-minute experience is unfeasible given available class time.

You will start this project with a focus on a single hand-crafted tutorialized city tier. Hand-crafting this level will help you discover and understand the game you are building.

Questions to be Answered as a Group

Answer the following questions in Figma. Work towards agreement. Don't get tied up in lore. Strive to keep your responses simple. Ambiguous or complex answers will provide poor guidance during the production phase.

Think high-level. Ideally each of your answers is a single sentence. Two sentences **max** per answer, except where stated.

Narrative Clarity

- What is the Moontower? (Also, is it canonically spelled Moontower, MoonTower, or Moon Tower?)
- Who is the main character and what motivates them?
- Narrative elements that need to be defined, changed, or removed:
 - Why does the story begin in an engine room? (Or does it?)
 - Why are there mechanical abominations and cold-blooded security officers? (Or are there?)
 - Why must the main character ascend the Moontower? (What's at the top that needs to be reached?)
 - What secrets are being revealed? (Secrets revealed through environmental storytelling could work well!)
- What's the beginning, middle, and end of your narrative arc? (Maximum 3 sentences.)
- How does the narrative justify the player mechanics? (Why is the main character able to do what they do?)

Design Questions

- How do you convey a towering metropolis in a locked axis side-scroller?
- How will depth be used in your level/environmental design?
- What's the planned camera system? Is it fixed side-scrolling centered on the player? Or something more dynamic?
 - Spring-arm dynamic – natural fluid movement zoom in / out - centered on character.
- Will keyboard, mouse, and controller all be supported? How about the arcade machine?
 - Start with keyboard, arcade machine is keyboard mapped.
 - Controller support (check FAB for leveraging existing systems).

Mechanics and Gameplay

- Will combat be the primary gameplay loop or will there be platforming and/or environmental hazards?
 - Platformer special areas (could be procedurally generated).
 - Define what you don't like about Dead Cells movement / combat. Source other games (depending on the amount of dislikes) to replace.
- In the Final Build of your Vertical Slice:
 - How many enemies will there be and what makes each one unique? (Maximum 1 sentence per enemy.)
 - 1 grunt (tier 1)
 - 2 colors each indicating a new difficulty and / or ability.
 - 1 elite (tier 2)
 - 2 colors each indicating a new difficulty and / or ability.

- 1 boss (tier 3)
- How many weapons will there be and what makes each one unique? (Maximum 1 sentence per weapon.)
 - Sword, Bow, Magic
- *Think about the timeline, available artists, and asset/animation requirements when deciding these counts.*

First Playable Build

Playtesting begins after the first two weeks of production.

- What features will be included in the first playtestable build? Think concentrically! (Max 1 sentence per feature.)
- What is the target move-set of this “First Playable”? (Subset of your Core Mechanics.)

Appendix B – Game Design Document Refinement and Port to Figma

Game Design Document sections to port to Figma:

- **Elevator Pitch:** Pitch your game in 3 sentences or less by stating the Genre, the Setting, and the Primary Conflict (who you are and what stands in your way). *Do this one last as it will be informed by the others.*
- **Hook:** Single sentence that identifies what will pull players into your game and keep them playing.
- **Target Audience:** Define the specific type of people playing this *at Grad Show* and how the game design accommodates their limited time and varying skill levels.
- **Player Objective:** State the game’s concrete 'Win Condition' obtainable in 3 to 5 minutes (example: 'Reach the rooftop antenna') and the one-sentence narrative reason why the character must do it now.
- **Core Mechanics:** The primary verbs/actions the player will perform during gameplay and what makes those actions satisfying to repeat.
- **Core Loop Description and Flow Chart:** Describe the repeating cycle of Action, Reward, and Decision that happens inside *a single game area*.
- **HUD:** More thought is needed on the HUD. A rough sketch of HUD elements is a good place to start.

Be sure to rework the GDD based on our feedback and questions listed in Appendix A. In some cases, there could be conflicting information in Figma already that will need to be updated or adopted.

Appendix C – Visual Identity and Style Pillars

In Figma you will create 3–5 Visual Identity Pillars. These pillars act as your project’s visual ruleset and will guide all future art decisions. Each pillar must include:

- A clear title
- 1–2 concise sentences describing the idea
- 1–2 supporting images that reinforce the point

What We’re Looking For

Your pillars should define your visual rules, not just your influences. Consider:

- Shape language: Are your forms boxy, rounded, tapered, exaggerated, grounded?
- Materials: Matte or roughness? Clean or noisy? Painterly or realistic?
- Color discipline: Limited palette or full spectrum? High contrast or restrained values?
- Rendering Style: You must clearly define the asset rendering style for your characters and environments.

You must include at least one comparison where you contrast two styles, for example:

- Wayfinder vs Arcane
- Arcane vs Guilty Gear Strive

Commented [DF3]: This section felt like a lot. I know we need to determine the enemies quickly to determine art requirements, but I have a hard time seeing them get through all this in two weeks.

Perhaps breaking it into sections (Core Player Experience, Level and Monsters, Items and Features) and laying it out in terms of priority rather than finality in places could help. E.G. For the player, determining the jump height needs to take place before the level can be designed. Abilities, powerups and items should be conditional to some degree, and highlighting what things **MUST** be there (probably NPCs due to art constraints) and what features **COULD** be there IF there was time (procedural generation of levels, powerups, additional abilities or weapons).

I think if they can get the basic player mechanic (like 2 or 3 attacks/abilities) and decide on the NPCs that would be a good milestone. If they have something working then we could talk about powerups, items, etc.

- Hand-painted vs stylized PBR

Then Define:

- What you're borrowing
- What you don't think works and *why*

Each pillar should answer both the *what* and the *why* using your references:

- Why does this reference work for your game?
- What specific elements are you borrowing (lighting, color, proportions, scale)?
- What are you explicitly not taking from the reference?

Define What Your Game Is NOT

Strong direction is just as much about exclusion as inclusion; you must also include visual examples that:

- Look cool, but don't fit your game.
- Break readability.
- Clash with the tone or gameplay.
- Compete with player visibility.

Clearly articulate *why* these examples are wrong, examples:

- "This breaks silhouette clarity"
- "This introduces too much visual noise"
- "There are too many (or too little) colors here."

Clarity Ensures Consistency

Clear visual identity pillars ensure that all team members share a visual target, assets remain consistent even when built by different artists, and creative disagreements can be resolved using clear visual rules instead of personal taste.

Appendix D – Marking Rubric

Scores are based on completeness, specificity, clarity, and consistency. A score of 4 indicates the artifact can be used immediately for project sprint planning without additional discussion.

Individual Contribution Accountability

Important: In the Learn Dropbox comment, list which students worked on each of the following three deliverables.

Deliverable 1 –Answers to Feedback Questions (Readiness Gate)

"Appendix A: Questions to be Answered as a Group" submitted as questions and answers in Figma. Make it readable.

READY:

- Every Appendix A question is answered.
- Each answer is a decision, not a discussion.
- Answers align with the updated Game Design Document sections in Figma.

NOT READY:

- Additional work required. Answers are missing, remain ambiguous, or contradict other deliverables.

Deliverable 2 — Game Design Document Refinement (/4)

“Appendix B: Game Design Document Refinement and Port to Figma” submitted in Figma. Make it readable.

4 marks: Production-foundation ready

All of the following are true:

- All required sections exist in Figma: Elevator Pitch, Hook, Target Audience, Player Objective, Core Mechanics, Core Loop + flow chart, HUD (with rough sketch).
- Each section meets its hard constraint:
 - Hook is a single sentence.
 - Objective includes a concrete win condition achievable in 3–5 minutes + one-sentence narrative reason.
 - Core Loop includes a flow chart of Action, Reward, Decision inside a single game area.
 - HUD includes at least a rough sketch of HUD elements.
- The ported GDD reads like a single coherent plan. (No conflicting info left in Figma. One source of truth)
- The content is written at a level where project planning can begin immediately without further discussion.

3 marks: Nearly production-usable

- All required sections exist but not all constraints are met.
- Minor missing specificity (e.g., objective is correct but mechanics/loop lack enough detail to implement cleanly).
- Minor inconsistencies exist but do not change scope or core experience.

2 marks: Not stable enough for production

- Required sections are present, but 2+ sections are vague, contradictory, or not actually constrained (e.g., objective not truly testable in 3–5 minutes; flow chart missing/hand-wavy; HUD not sketched).
- Conflicting pre-existing Figma content is still present/uncleared.

0–1 marks: Incomplete

- Missing sections and/or violates key constraints (Hook not 1 sentence, no flow chart, no HUD sketch, etc.).
- Reads like ideation rather than an implementable plan.

Deliverable 3 — Visual Identity / Style Pillars (/4)

“Appendix C – Visual Identity and Style Pillars” submitted in Figma. Make it easy to quickly review these pillars.

4 marks: Production-foundation ready

All of the following are true:

- Contains 3–5 pillars.
- Each pillar includes title + 1–2 concise sentences + 1–2 images.
- Pillars define rules, not just influences, and explicitly cover actionable choices like:
 - shape language, materials, color discipline.
- Rendering style is locked with at least one explicit comparison (style A vs style B), and clearly states:
 - what you’re borrowing
 - what doesn’t work and why
 - what you are explicitly not taking.
- Includes a “Game Is NOT” section with examples and specific reasons tied to readability/visibility/tone.
- Pillars function as a ruleset that lets the team resolve disagreements, keeping assets consistent across artists.

3 — Actionable direction, minor gaps

- All required pieces exist, but one area is under-specified (e.g., rendering comparison conclusions are a bit thin, or “NOT” examples exist but reasons aren’t consistently concrete).

2 — Present but vibes-driven

- 3–5 pillars exist but read mostly like a moodboard (“cool references”) rather than constraints.
- Rendering style comparison exists but borrowing/exclusions are unclear or unjustified.
- “Game is NOT” exists but reasons are generic (not tied to readability/visibility/tone).

0-1 — Missing requirements

- Fewer than 3 pillars or missing required pillar structure.
- Missing rendering comparison requirements and/or missing “Game is NOT” section with reasons.

